





STAGING MAGIC Scenes from *Matilda: The Musical*

mistress. "There is a connotation to the word rebellious that's negative... it's not that," says Gilhome. "Matilda has a moral compass that is so clear for her." The show, she adds, offers valuable lessons—"to stand up for yourself and inspire others around you when you see something that isn't right, and be brave enough to make a change."

Matilda isn't the first international production featuring kids to be staged at the NMACC. The last one to do so—*The Sound of Music*—was a hit as the tiny von Trapp siblings delighted audiences with their lovely voices and cuteness quotient. For Nita Mukesh Ambani, founder and chairperson of NMACC, *Matilda* was a perfect fit for summer, for "it is a tale of courage, kinship, and adventure—qualities that resonate deeply with me as a teacher, mother, and now grandmother".

The part of Matilda will be rotated among three kids, with each being accompanied by a parent and also continuing studies on tour. "When we are directing the girls, we are reminding them they are the adults in the room," says Natalie. Some of the tracks to look out for include the rousing finale 'Revolting Children' and 'When I Grow Up', which sees the kids dreaming about the freedoms they will have when they grow up, including eating lollies and candies while going to work, 'Naughty' rendered by who else but Matilda, and 'My House' in which Matilda and her teacher Miss Honey enjoy a cup of hot sweet tea and butter biscuits. Gilhome assures that adults will have their share of entertainment as much as the kids do. "It's such a beautiful, clever show that has layers to it," she says. ■

–Suhani Singh

part of a single-minded quest. "Cinema-going has to become an event that you cannot enjoy on the mobile phone or TV. It has to blow you away," says Malhotra.

He knows well that creating compelling imagery by deploying the green screen isn't enough to lure viewers. Visual effects, he notes, are "not just meant to wow you but also [make you] believe in something that's happening". That's possible with "immersive, high-quality storytelling and characterisation". It's why Malhotra is not disclosing a timeline to *Ramayana*, the Nitesh Tiwari-directed trilogy which is generating much hype. "*Ramayana* has to be as big if not better than anything else you have seen. That's the single-handed driver to do it," he says.

The epic is Malhotra's second big bet as producer after 2022's *Brahmastra*, which set a new benchmark in Hindi cinema with its CGI (computer-generated imagery). For Malhotra, it has already accomplished what he set out to do, with Indian directors becoming "more comfortable" with the technology than the previous generation.

It wasn't the case earlier, which is why in 2006 he headed westwards. By 2014, Malhotra merged his company, Prime Focus, with British company Double Negative and worked with Christopher Nolan (*Inception*, *Interstellar*, *Tenet*), *Blade Runner 2049*, *First Man* and *Ex Machina*, all of which won Oscars for best visual effects. It's why filmmaker George Miller and producer Doug Mitchell asked him to set up shop in Sydney and work with them on *Furiosa*, the prequel to the action entertainer, *Mad Max: Fury Road* (2015).

The stakes for cinemas are only getting bigger with leading streaming platforms investing big money to create spectacles of their own. DNEG's OTT work includes *Masters of the Air* (Apple TV) and *The Lord of the Rings: The Rings of Power* (Amazon Prime). Big or small screen, Malhotra ensures entertainment is guaranteed. ■

–Suhani Singh

May sees the release of **THE GARFIELD MOVIE**, of which Malhotra is a producer, and **FURIOSA**, on which his company has worked extensively

A scene from *Furiosa*

